



SAVRABHI CHHABRA



REBELS: (top) ICL teams; (above) Lalu Yadav at the opening ceremony of ICL in Chandigarh

Disputes with a churlish coach, determined players and an adamant chief selector looked like insignificant scraps when compared to their duel with a deep-pocketed, stubborn adversary called the Indian Cricket League (ICL), promoted by Subhash Chandra's Zee Group with Kapil Dev as its calling card. Almost Kerry Packeresque in its philosophy, ICL set out to attract the best of the under-

paid domestic talent with a lure of financial security and a stage which would also feature some of the world's best, albeit in many cases retired, cricketers. But barely had they announced Brian Lara as their prized catch when a sharp blow was delivered to counter their first punch. BCCI showcased its clout and announced the Indian Premier League (IPL). With team franchises up for sale, and international celebrities reportedly evincing interest, would BCCI win this match in the first over itself?

ICL proved to be a worthy adversary. Chandra's baby did take the first steps and she didn't even trip and fall. The inaugural ICL in Chandigarh was successful and four more editions in 2008 were announced. IPL, on the other hand, is scheduled to kick off in April. Teething troubles are being felt, with international boards like Cricket Australia unwilling to spare star players from domestic engagements. BCCI is unlikely to let such minor details cow them down. The contest for the T20 franchise in India should prove to be a humdinger.

Apart from a desire to quench the rebellion, BCCI's affinity for T20 is also a consequence of India's triumph at the Twenty20 World Cup, as well as the resounding success of the format. Their one-time disdain for the 20-over-a-side game was set aside. It was a potential money spinner, how could they resist?

There were other fall-outs too of the T20 team's success. The seniors versus juniors debate raged like wildfire, as every expert in the country offered a point of view on how to phase out experience from the team. These knee-jerk opinions were put paid to when the seasoned hands held their own in India's intermittent success, in England as well as at home. Dhoni was anointed one-day captain, but 37-year-old Anil Kumble was given responsibility for the Test team.

The age-old conflict of cricket lording over the rest also revisited Indian sport after this victory.



We heard Mumbai is always on the move. Today, we brought Mumbai to a standstill.

M.S. DHONI,
INDIA'S T20 CAPTAIN



I heard about it (the welcome given to the cricket team). It would be interesting to see what kind of reception I get when I come to India by the end of this month (October).

VISWANATHAN ANAND,
WORLD CHESS CHAMPION



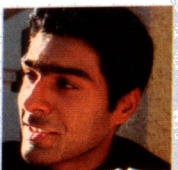
DRIBBLE GOES WRONG

Score a goal, get Rs 1,000. Concede one, pay Rs 2,000. IHF chief K.P.S. Gill (left) mooted this formula during the Asia Cup. Thankfully, it was never enforced.



NEW RACE

Narain Karthikeyan's (left) position as the 'fastest driver in India' was challenged by Karun Chandok (right).



BCCI Vs KING KHAN



Shah Rukh Khan (right), with *Om Shanti Om* ready for release, turned cheerleader for Team India. BCCI's Niranjan Shah (left) was reportedly unhappy at cricket being used to promote a movie. Khan was unfazed but surely won't be shouting *Chak De* for BCCI.